BuildRight Construction - Personal Protective Equipment (PPE) Rules

Document PPE-02, revision 3

1. General principles

Personal protective equipment is the last line of defence. It never replaces collective protection measures (guardrails, extraction, barriers, safe work methods), which must be put in place first. PPE is supplied free of charge by BuildRight. Workers must wear it correctly, keep it clean and report any damage to their supervisor immediately. Damaged PPE must be replaced before work continues.

All PPE must carry the CE marking and comply with the relevant European standard.

2. Minimum PPE for everyone on site

The following PPE is mandatory at all times for every person on site, including visitors, from the moment they pass the site gate:

- Safety helmet (EN 397), worn with the chin strap fastened when working at height.
- High-visibility vest or jacket, class 2 minimum (EN ISO 20471).
- Safety footwear with toe cap and puncture-resistant midsole, category S3 (EN ISO 20345).

The only exceptions are inside site offices, canteens and welfare cabins.

3. Head protection

Helmets must be replaced every 3 years from the date of manufacture, or immediately after any significant impact, even if no damage is visible. Stickers and paint are forbidden on helmets because solvents can weaken the shell. Bump caps are not a substitute for safety helmets on site.

4. Eye and face protection

Safety glasses (EN 166) are mandatory for any task producing dust, chips or splashes: drilling, grinding, cutting, chiselling, handling cement or chemicals. A full face shield is required in addition to safety glasses for grinding with an angle grinder and for cutting with a disc cutter. Welders must use a welding helmet with a suitable filter (EN 175 / EN 169).

5. Hearing protection

Hearing protection (ear plugs EN 352-2 or ear muffs EN 352-1) must be worn when the noise level exceeds 85 dB(A), and in all signposted hearing protection zones. As a rule of thumb, if you have to raise your voice to be understood by someone 1 metre away, the noise level is probably above 85 dB(A). Tools that always require hearing protection include: disc cutters and cut-off saws, jackhammers and breakers, angle grinders, circular saws, and compactors.

6. Respiratory protection

Respiratory protection is required whenever dust, fumes or vapours cannot be controlled by collective measures. The minimum level depends on the task:

- General dust (sweeping, demolition of non-hazardous materials): FFP2 disposable mask (EN 149).
- Silica dust (cutting, grinding or drilling concrete, brick, stone or tiles): FFP3 mask minimum (EN 149), combined with wet cutting or on-tool dust extraction.
- Asbestos: work only by certified specialist contractors with powered air-purifying respirators.
- Solvents and paint spraying: half mask with A2 gas filter (EN 14387).

Workers who use tight-fitting masks must be clean-shaven where the mask seals on the face and must have passed a face-fit test.

7. Hand protection

Gloves must be adapted to the hazard: cut-resistant gloves (EN 388, cut level C minimum) for handling sheet metal, glass or rebar; chemical-resistant gloves (EN ISO 374) for handling cement, mortar, resins and solvents; anti-vibration gloves (EN ISO 10819) for prolonged use of vibrating tools. Wet cement causes severe burns: never let it stay in contact with the skin.

8. Fall protection equipment

When collective protection against falls is not possible, workers must wear a full body harness (EN 361) connected to a suitable anchor point by an energy-absorbing lanyard (EN 355) or a self-retracting lifeline (EN 360). Waist belts are forbidden for fall arrest. Harnesses are inspected by the user before each use and by a competent person every 6 months. Any harness that has arrested a fall must be withdrawn from service. See procedure WAH-03 for details.

9. PPE by task - summary table

The table below lists the PPE required in addition to the minimum PPE (helmet, high-visibility vest, S3 safety footwear).

Concrete cutting, core drilling and chasing: safety glasses plus full face shield, FFP3 mask (silica dust), hearing protection, cut-resistant gloves, and anti-vibration gloves for prolonged use. Wet cutting or on-tool extraction is mandatory. If wet cutting is used, waterproof clothing and boots are recommended.

Concrete pouring and finishing: chemical-resistant gloves, safety glasses, waterproof boots (wellington type, S5), and long sleeves to avoid skin contact with wet concrete.

Welding and hot work: welding helmet, flame-retardant clothing (EN ISO 11611), leather welding gloves (EN 12477), and a respirator with fume filter when working indoors.

Working at height above 2 metres without collective protection: full body harness with energy-absorbing lanyard, helmet with chin strap fastened.

Demolition and breaking: safety glasses, FFP2 mask minimum (FFP3 if the material contains silica), hearing protection, anti-vibration gloves.

Handling rebar and steel: cut-resistant gloves, safety glasses. Exposed rebar ends must be fitted with protective caps.

Work near traffic or plant: high-visibility clothing class 3 (EN ISO 20471).

Electrical work: insulating gloves (EN 60903) of the class matching the voltage, arc-flash face shield where required by the risk assessment.

10. Training and sanctions

Every worker receives PPE training during the site induction, and specific training for harnesses and respirators. A worker found without the mandatory PPE is stopped and receives a verbal warning; a second offence leads to a written warning, and a third to removal from the site.